Luis Alvarez



Considered one of the greatest physicists of the 20th century, Luis Alvarez was born in San Francisco in 1911. He graduated from the University of Chicago in 1936 and went on to work at the Radiation Laboratory in the University of California, Berkeley. There he helped develop nuclear reactors and, during World War II, nuclear weapons. He witnessed the atomic bombing of Hiroshima and helped build a plutonium bomb.

After the war, Alvarez developed the liquid hydrogen bubble chamber, used to discover new subatomic particles. For this, in 1968 he was awarded the Nobel Prize for Physics. Later he provided the calculations to back up the Alvarez Hypothesis of mass extinction caused by a meteor strike. He died in 1988.

Key works

1980 "Extraterrestrial Cause for the Cretaceous–Tertiary Extinction," *Science*

1985 "The Hydrogen Bubble Chamber and the Strange Resonances"

1987 *Alvarez: Adventures of a Physicist*

Marine annihilation

The earliest mass extinction, and the second-most catastrophic, occurred when our planet cooled dramatically, toward the end of the Ordovician period, around 444 million years ago. At this time, most organisms on Earth